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Chaucer in the Age of AI: Critical and Collaborative Translation in Digital Medieval Studies

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The Pardoner from the Ellesmere manuscript (Public domain, Berkeley Library, US).

Abstract: *Little is known about AI's ability to generate and interpret issues of the distant past, especially as the topic of medieval public life is not a priority when producing new AI technologies. Yet there is recent hype around university students using generative AI to produce responses that might guide them in their degree programme. This case study analyses qualitative data from current students and teachers working on medieval history, language and literature, to understand the pedagogical principles guiding translations of works from the Middle Ages, and whether LLMs assist or hinder this process. It also discusses the development of an educational prototype interface of Geoffrey Chaucer's Pardoner's Prologue and Tale, and provides critical suggestions for the use of generative AI to investigate medieval texts, following the work of the AHRC/IRC-funded project C21 Editions. The paper concludes that the following endeavours must be accommodated in higher education contexts if generative AI is to be used for the study of Chaucer's texts, themes and role in the literary canon: a) sufficient space to critically engage with and raise issues related to new technologies in the (digital) classroom; b) explorations of the evolving concepts and topics in Chaucer studies, discussing issues of sociohistorical injustice and marginalisation; and c) opportunities to bring together teaching and learning community insights via regular classroom-based activities. Such activities should incorporate discussion of LLMs' ethical concerns and possibilities for increased collaboration and creativity during the process of producing accessible modern English translations.*

Keywords: *generative AI; higher education; digital classrooms; Chaucer; medieval studies; translation; collaboration; critical pedagogy*

Introduction

In the current age of AI, communicating the skills of (digital) humanists, particularly those researching and reproducing the medieval past through scholarly editions, remains vital. The importance of digital humanities was articulated by Melissa Terras in her keynote to the Digital Humanities Congress, where she stressed that expertise from the humanities prompts conversation about the concerns of competing AI technologies (Terras, 2024). As evidenced by projects such as *Transkribus*, an Automated Text Recognition (ATR) service, there is a place for AI in an edition if supported by adequate experimentation and sustained input from the communities these resources aim to assist (Terras et al., 2024, p. 9). These values are crucial for students in higher education (HE), who have been placed at the forefront of discussions on plagiarism due to concerns that they will rush to use AI in their studies. At the same time, students' insights on AI 'tools' are invaluable for emphasising the role and power of human knowledge in the face of profit-making AI corporations (Murgia, 2023).

In this case study, I explore first-hand insight from students and teachers at UK and US institutions, which drove the development of a digital teaching edition prototype of 14th century poet, Geoffrey Chaucer (the *C21 Editions* project). The project focused on AI's capabilities in interpreting Chaucer's *Pardoner's Prologue and Tale* (PPT) from *The Canterbury Tales*; a medieval text that explores the Pardoner pilgrim as he confesses to his transgressions while delivering a tale on morality.¹ More specifically, I analyse the impact of the knowledge and intuitions of learners, teachers and editors alongside an AI-generated translation of Middle English, in the context of digital learning environments. Generative artificial intelligence (generative AI) often uses Large Language Models (or generative pre-trained transformers; 'chatbots' such as ChatGPT) to scope training datasets for statistical patterns, make predictions through these patterns, and generate new content. These chatbots are more widely known by the public for their 'ease' of performing a wide range of natural language processing tasks following user prompts.

Driven by user requirements, a digital, experimental approach within pedagogical editions can help students learn about editorial decision-making processes, and introduce flexibility when they undertake translation from medieval to modern Englishes. Yet, the introduction of generative AI to university classrooms poses a further challenge to this approach, and students must be made aware of the flaws of the technology. By analysing the capabilities and limitations of generative AI, students also have the opportunity to raise questions about Chaucer's role in the curriculum. This case study advises that students critically assess the flaws of AI at every point in the learning process. Here, I present a project snapshot during its earliest iterations, to later inform editorial workflows and AI benchmarking within digital pedagogy.

First, I contextualise the digital space by drawing on critical AI research, collaboration, and new perspectives for studying Chaucer and medieval translation. I then briefly detail the methods, before analysing three key findings. The first set of findings explores students' interest in experimenting and collaborating on new approaches with their peers, to ascertain their thoughts on evolving generative AI technologies, and the impact on their digital learning. The second finding investigates students' interest in translation of Chaucer's works, during a period of disengagement in medieval studies, and how the additional layer of AI complicates this picture.

Lastly, the third finding shows how translation tasks within digital teaching editions lead to shared knowledge and crowdsourced content when embedding a critical approach to AI. This final section highlights the developer response within the project team, to build an edition which centres the user while evaluating the reliability and efficacy of AI methods of digital editing.

Background: Critical AI, Chaucer, and Medieval Translation

Critical AI Literacies in Higher Education

The release of OpenAI's Large Language Model (LLM), ChatGPT, sparked increasing concern in higher education institutions for the integrity of academic study. In a piece for *The Conversation* around the time of the release of ChatGPT version 3.5, Wierdak and Sheridan (2023) stated that students are susceptible to plagiarism via 'contract cheating', with assignments outsourced due to time and financial constraints. They claimed that a potential solution for reducing plagiarism is to treat ChatGPT as "friend not foe"—students use generative AI as a tool for education, rather than a substitute for writing essays. In turn, they suggest that prompting ChatGPT would encourage academic integrity and provide opportunities for students to provoke insightful questions for their degree course (Wierdak and Sheridan, 2023). They acknowledge that departments must clearly research and articulate the limitations and implications of AI models on specific disciplines. If AI is to be used as a research tool to improve creativity, reflection and critical thinking, it must also be embedded in a programme where students can probe flawed LLMs like any other source or methodology (Conrad and Goodlad, 2024)

If there is a lack of awareness about the capabilities and implications of LLMs on academic study, there is no student agency alongside these technologies promoted as research 'tools'. It is now well-known that students' use of generative AI responses in assignments may be flagged as (un)intentional plagiarism, since LLMs cannot consistently credit its sources. Some models may assist in 'levelling the playing field'; there is evidence that AI tools can guide disabled and neurodivergent students in their tasks, such as text summarisation, proofreading and task breakdown (Zhao, Cox and Chen, 2024). At the same time, they may also reproduce harmful stereotypes and discrimination against marginalised identities, by recreating biases in their scraped training data. The issue therefore lies in how educators can best shape understanding and awareness of the harms of LLMs within the teaching and learning community, whether or not teachers decide to integrate generative AI into the university classroom.

Emphasis has now been placed on the need for student 'AI literacy', with some institutions running sessions for students to increase their awareness of the benefits and limitations of LLMs in society. For instance, Zhao, Cox and Cai (2024) investigated the benefits of ChatGPT for writing in HE, identifying key areas of understanding which involve students interpreting outputted information critically, reflecting on AI's impact on their learning, understanding socio-ethical implications, and deciding whether its use is necessary in a particular context. Within the digital humanities, Chun and Elkins' (2023) case study highlights that the use of human-centred AI is rich for making links between software engineers and domain experts, with students working at the intersection of both roles. They conclude that to not fully engage with and collaborate in a world where companies are competing to develop the most 'intelligent' AI software, would lead "the world to unchecked AI

progress that optimizes returns rather than human flourishing” (2023, p. 159). Ultimately, they advocate for students’ participation in public solutions to current technological demands in society; decisions which are rooted in learning environments and increase the agency to which students can evaluate AI technologies.

The focus in pedagogical contexts should then be on *critical* AI literacies, which promote the ability to “evaluate tools, understand their affordances and failure modes, and explore their provenance and implications (social, environmental, and ethical)” (Conrad and Goodlad, 2024). This practice goes beyond preparing students for future employment, but instead empowers students to conduct investigations into the technologies in front of them, and make decisions about whether its use is responsible in a specific context. Critical AI literacy documents, such as Rutgers AI Council living document, are vital for tutors, educators and governing bodies (Goodlad and Stoerger, 2023-). Goodlad (2023) advocates for balance amongst the current AI hype, with space occupied between ‘doomerism’ and ‘boosterism’. These extreme stances promote an anthropomorphic AI, which neither poses immediate risk to society nor has the potential to replace all human tasks. Models that attempt to mimic human behaviour must be investigated further to ensure their benefits outweigh the risks of harm, as per the well-known Bender et al. (2021) paper on LLMs as “stochastic parrots”.

Critical AI literacy is especially pertinent for studying the past, particularly historical textual traditions and narratives, and in this case, Chaucer’s perceptions on the medieval world. The limitations of LLMs for interpreting and generating information about medieval society should be highlighted, in spite of limited training data on Middle English and its transmission through time. Specifically, critical engagement with AI makes visible the flaws of the model when medieval texts can be far removed from our present reality. Despite the shortcomings of the technology itself, this case study shows that the use of critical AI pedagogies within Chaucer and medieval studies empowers students to hone their skills in reading and translating Middle English, and to appreciate the sociocultural and linguistic changes occurring between the past and present.

Context: Chaucer and Medieval Translation Studies

If generative AI is to be used within Chaucer studies, the main focus must be to critically assess whether LLMs can accurately interpret and convey the nuances of medieval texts. Even if the model can draw on traditional research to describe and explain the main themes within Chaucer’s texts, the primary challenge is to determine whether it can also scrape cutting-edge scholarship relevant today. This section details the recent calls for the inclusion of different identities in Chaucer studies, and how these voices may be uncovered if AI-generated translation reproduces bias and conceals them. After surveying the state of Chaucer studies at British universities in 2021, Edwards wrote that Chaucer’s de-prioritisation preceded redundancies at the University of Leicester, with “courses on ‘race, ethnicity, sexuality and diversity’” brought to the fore (Edwards, 2021, p. 7). This issue is therefore said to lie in calls to reject Chaucer’s place in the canon at universities in favour of literature described as decolonial—a necessary investigation prior to understanding whether LLMs can interpret Chaucer’s works.

Evans (2022) argues for maintaining Chaucer's place on the curriculum by expanding conversation to communities that adapt and decentre works written from white, patriarchal lenses. For instance, *Refugee Tales* takes the frame narrative of *The Canterbury Tales* and centres the stories of refugees in the 21st century. Chaucer's literature can therefore be shifted to draw attention to identities that are obscured through history. The Pardoner presents a complex scenario where Chaucer's construction of the character fundamentally challenges the binary modes of thinking in the Middle Ages, by presenting fluidity in his gender identity and sexuality. The character is positioned to be "obscured, disowned and pushed to the margin" by Chaucer himself and the other pilgrims in the tale (Dhouib, 2021, p. 164, citing Gross, 1995). The existence of the Pardoner's character thus leads to more open conversation and increased engagement by students of today. Baechle and Harris' (2021) special issue also highlights how the ethical questions raised by studying the Chaucerian literary canon is necessarily accompanied by an interrogation of attitudes towards women, racialised people and the queer community. By teaching Chaucer, students are provided with the tools to critique literature rooted in white supremacy and heteronormativity. Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales* is rich for thinking critically about topics of representation in the Middle Ages, which can be done without "deifying" white authors (Baechle and Harris, 2021, p. 318). Any use of generative AI to provide answers to these questions must therefore be rooted in this type of assessment of medieval literary canons, a process which tends to occur in collaborative settings alongside in-depth research of secondary sources and criticism. LLMs must therefore be paired with peer-reviewed research that problematises Chaucer's continuity on current university curricula, especially as these models tend to draw on early academic research.

In terms of the readers of today, criticism of Chaucer's language and literature often occurs through the more accessible medium of translation to modern Englishes.² This is particularly true of students' learning within Chaucer studies, whose first engagement with medieval literature may be in their first year of university. Teachers interviewed for the *C21 Editions* project referenced their experience delivering translation assignments in university sessions on Chaucer. They mentioned the difficulties experienced by students whose first language was not English, and limited provisions to analyse Middle English language in any depth. This learning community therefore advocated for more opportunities for community translation, where novices of Middle English could still access hidden layers of editorial decision-making, and offer more freedom in translation by incorporating different communities' languages, dialects and insights. Whether recent AI technologies can replicate core principles of community translation adds another complex layer to the process of accessing medieval language.

There are particular challenges for students and editors when undertaking medieval translation. Baker (2011, p. 18-23) outlines the central issue of non-equivalence, when there is no suitably equivalent word available to the translator. These problems involve differences in cultural-specific concepts and the existence of loan words (adopted from another language) in the source text but not the target language, causing issues with 'one-to-one mapping'. Relinquishing some of the rigid rules around equivalence might instead make the process of translation creative, especially where educators are encouraging engagement with older languages. In particular, translation processes that offer students opportunities to contribute their insight to an extract might improve accessibility and increase the appeal of Middle English translation. For instance, Linn adopts multiple approaches in her translation of medieval poetry. She acknowledges the importance of

context; for example, reimagining the poem's rhyme scheme might be more meaningful to the reader than labouring over equivalences of concepts and ideas (2023a, p. 75). Linn (2023b) also recognises the high frequency of non-gendered and ambiguous Middle English pronouns, such as *he* and *hire* (first person singular or third person plural pronouns), meaning desires and references to gender can be reconfigured for modern audiences. Another vital element of editorial practices, particularly translations, is making a typically invisible process, visible. Venuti (2017, p. 1) speaks to illusions of transparency in translation; when the use of a form that more 'accurately' reflects the author's intentions, or improves modern readability, hides the translator's deliberations over a term and their bias. Enriching translations with flexibility and transparency might therefore lead to more open perspectives of medieval literature for students.

In the 21st century, LLMs provide an additional layer of obscurity to the translation process. There are already known issues with neural machine translation (NMT), which models sentences by predicting the likelihood of strings of words. NMTs perform poorly with words of low frequency due to small training vocabularies, as well as languages beyond those on which the model was trained. There is also a preference for literal and/or equivalent translations (Koehn and Knowles, 2017). Similar issues arise when using LLMs to translate medieval languages. The priorities of competing corporations are to produce conversational interfaces for its users, rather than niche tasks such as medieval translation, meaning increased attention to error and bias in the translated output is required. The potential solution to a lack of transparency, flexibility and community with (AI-generated) medieval translation may be to provide opportunities for collaboration and open discussion by contributors of differing types of expertise, from beginners through to academic and professional translators. Pym (2015, p. 117) explains that "the medieval can help us think about where we stand in time, and how technologies open possibilities." Due to the demand for transparency within the AI-generated translation process, increased collaboration to examine these outputs allows us to reflect on the histories that led to the thought of today.

Benefits to Collaborative Digital Teaching Editions

AI use in HE and the humanities must occur in an environment where student development is a consequence of teachers' knowledge, independent research into authoritative secondary scholarship, and clear expectations for their degree programme, with the space to critique and create. In addition to independent learning, HE courses in the UK and US encourage group-based learning. The sentiments reflected in our focus groups suggest that students and teachers tackle complex textual traditions and translations through small learning communities of peers and colleagues. In the current age of technology, a digital teaching edition, where critical AI and collaborative translation can be merged, is one solution for new approaches to Chaucer studies. Here, I explore recent digital teaching practices, as well as future directions for the field.

Digital pedagogical editions, including learning of traditional and contemporary editorial practices, have been implemented successfully in university contexts. Harris (2023, p. 6) finds ways to incorporate digital tools into sessions, recognising the importance of play and empowering students to demonstrate the tool's classroom applicability to their peers. Harris finds that DH pedagogical contexts foster collaboration, which is central to students' "productivity, learning, experimenting, and knowledge acquisition" (2023, p. 10). Research-focussed collaboration is not

only beneficial for academic merit and career prospects, but is part of life-long learning that encourages intellectual curiosity and partnership. The act of “screwing around”, involving cyclical processes of digital experimentation and feedback in one space (Harris, 2023, pp. 10-11), is pertinent to medieval translation, where there are multiple linguistic and literary interpretations of Middle English. One successful case of undergraduate digital editing and collaboration is Taylor’s (2019) implementation of a digital Shakespearean text at Northwestern University, Illinois, where “critical pedagogy” was emphasised. This approach empowered students to be a voice of authority on influential authors like William Shakespeare (2019, p. 133). The editorial role of the students, where they collaborated and (dis)agreed on decisions and connected personally with issues such as “queerness or questions of social justice” (Taylor, 2019, p. 135), provided a gateway for in-depth investigation of sources and datasets. Furthermore, Sutherland’s (2022) examination of scholarly editing pedagogies via the nineteenth-century *Seward Family Digital Archive* indicated students’ willingness to assist their peers with editorial concerns. Sutherland provides an example of a student who encountered the barriers of archaisms to interpretation and markup, and developed a method of communication for future student transcribers through glossaries, to ensure transcription consistency (2022, p. 6). These examples show that engagement with digital pedagogical editions enhance student’s communication skills, fostering spaces to critique and build on historical textual and linguistic traditions alongside peers.

More recently, DH scholars have looked to embed Text Encoding Initiative (TEI) and XML/HTML skills into their courses. Cummings (2024) and Connell (2024) discuss the challenges of implementing TEI in the university classroom, but also highlight clear learning benefits. In particular, Cummings (2024, pp. 16-17) explains that students are unlikely to access library archival materials and training voluntarily to guide them on their course. Cummings thus introduces students to editorial theory and delivers practical, hands-on sessions on transcription, markup and digital publishing, which prompt students to consider aspects of digital editing in their humanities-based courses. Likewise, Connell (2014, pp. 19–20) recognised the technical demands on educators to deliver digital editing and TEI-based modules, but explained that students in practical sessions are more likely to cooperate to tackle layered challenges of textual mediation, including transcription, annotation, and regularisation, becoming informed and critical editorial decision-makers.

There is, however, a need to recognise the students who do not have DH provisions on their course. Dase and Atkins (2021, p. 23) point out that there must be resources which encourage researchers outside of digital editing and publishing to participate in conversation on new technologies. They highlight that projects such as *Estoria de Espanna Digital*, which developed principles for crowdsourcing witnesses for the chronicle of Spain, are particularly adept at engaging non-specialists through helpful YouTube tutorials on the material aspects of historical textual traditions. It is these resources and collaboration opportunities, tools and skills (also developed by Cummings and Connell), that might sway students to appreciate the value of digital humanities research within their field of expertise. For medieval studies courses where there is no digital humanities provision, the question remains as to how students might sustain interest in investigating new technologies for learning about the Middle Ages, if they have little-to-no experience of Middle English or digital editing. There is the further challenge of inspiring interest in Chaucer’s works, when his presence on the curriculum at further and higher education

institutions is declining. These established teaching practices raise the question as to whether LLMs have the potential to further enhance digital tools, or are a cause for concern in Chaucer studies and beyond.

Methods

This study investigates students' experiences with Chaucer's literature, where their first engagement with the topic may be a digital teaching edition, and where generative AI may be an appealing method for investigating medieval society. The main methods for obtaining various types of expertise on AI use, the study of Chaucer and the challenges of medieval translation, were via focus groups and interviews with current students and lecturers in UK and US higher education institutions.³ The *C21 Editions* project sought to obtain insights on digital pedagogy from people at different levels of their degree programme or career stage. This process allowed for collaborative, peer-led discussion on the use of generative AI for translation of Chaucer's texts. I also provide analysis of an example of AI-generated translation, which came from the team working closely with these pedagogical insights to produce a teaching edition prototype of *The Pardoner's Prologue and Tale*. The *C21* team consisted of academic researchers, editors and a research software engineer in digital humanities. These insights come together to form possible solutions to critical and collaborative AI use in HE, as well as resolving some of the above concerns in Chaucer and medieval translation studies.

Undergraduate and postgraduate students (some of whom were teachers as part of their graduate course) registered to attend focus groups with a member of the project team at two universities in the UK and one in the US, where discussion of Chaucer's position on the curriculum is prevalent (e.g. see Edwards, 2021; Baechle and Harris, 2021; Evans, 2022). Students were recruited through the mailing lists of lecturers who were contacts of the project team, and these teachers were also interviewed. Lecturers were at different career stages, from early career researchers, through to established researchers and professors. Thirteen students and six teachers participated in total, with their disciplines spanning historical linguistics, medieval English literature, and history.

Focus groups and reciprocal peer interviews were selected as the main methods for obtaining qualitative data and insights from the learning and teaching community, due to their effectiveness in generating ideas naturally and forming co-creation spaces between students or teachers and the observer or interviewer. In focus groups, the facilitator intervened only to steer conversation towards a new topic or to ask for the experiences of quieter members of the group (e.g. see Bryman, 2012, p. 501). The topics mentioned in the previous sections were presented to prompt discussion in the focus groups. The aim of reciprocal peer interviews was to reduce power differentials present between interviewer and interviewee by fostering peer-like and collegial conversations with educators. Both parties co-construct elements of the interview throughout (Porter et al., 2009, p. 306), mirroring natural conversation between colleagues. Possible topics and questions were provided to contributors in advance, with the facilitator asking follow-up questions based on the insights they raised.

Key Findings and Analysis

The below findings reinforce the main principles of Harris (2023), arising from the affordances of digital pedagogy, which centre students' drive to experiment with different digital methods. In doing so, I show that degree courses that allow for 'productive failure' are most suitable for embedding AI responsibly, as students sustain critical thinking skills, build original and interdisciplinary projects as groups, and share this knowledge with their peers within the digital humanities and beyond. I highlight that digital tools partially created by an LLM must combine critical and collaborative AI perspectives to provide accessible, flexible and community translations of Chaucer's narratives, particularly as the university curriculum continues to evolve.

Classroom Experimentation and Engagement with Digital Methods and Generative AI

I begin with a discussion on students' experimentation with various digital resources, to provide a base for discussing their thoughts on AI. From our dataset, we established that teachers empower students to seek new opportunities for data collection, interpretation and analysis of medieval language and literature through digital methods. Relatedly, students pay close attention to the role of modern editors in interpreting older texts through endeavours such as translation. I also noted that students and their teachers regularly evaluate how AI impacts their area of study, and they shared ideas about how it might be implemented responsibly and ethically in pedagogical spaces. Here, I propose that a firm foundation, with opportunities to trial digital methods alongside their peers, must be established in degree courses to improve the agency to which students engage with AI.

Students recognise the linguistic hurdle of reading and commenting on Middle English in the present-day. Almost all students in our focus groups agreed on the benefits of classroom 'readalongs' to comprehend Middle English narratives, before delving into the linguistic and cultural consequences of texts on medieval society. *S3* emphasised that collective involvement in Middle English reading is crucial for meaning:

"Once it's gone around the whole class, and everyone has done it, I feel like you get that sense that you're a lot more involved. [...] All of a sudden you get the sense that it genuinely is a polyphony—there are all these voices across the text constantly talking over each other."

(ID: *S3*)

Students appreciate group-based learning of Middle English, for both greater accessibility in understanding the language, and to take in the multiplicity of voices, puns, irony and satire. From this initial learning curve, students become more involved in collaborative digital editing and decision-making, regardless of whether their course has a digital humanities focus. For instance, *S3* mentioned the often inaccessible critical editions, highlighting the need for educational editions which run through potential word options, so students can learn from and replicate the translation and editorial process in assignments. Students taught to use physical critical editions to uncover interpretations were also provided the space to be creative, as shown by their interactivity ideas for editions. Within the space of the focus group, *S8* presented her ideas for an interactive

translation game for testing students' knowledge of Middle English words, with audio for improved accessibility. *S7* supported this idea with her preferred way of learning, referencing a regularly updated 'Living Library' she used to share important secondary research with her peers. These viewpoints indicate the scope to explore students' original ideas of translation and accessibility, whether that is part of the scholarly editing process, or to directly impact the learning of other students.

Their teachers – interviewed in a separate space – reinforced students' enthusiasm for being involved in the digital editing process regardless of linguistic challenges. One professor (*T2*) encourages students to focus on codicology, to consider historical problems of production, reception and interpretation of the book. Students were asked to produce project proposals where they can apply their observational skills to plan an edition. One student compiled hashtag outputs on Twitter, specifically the '#MeToo movement', drawing attention to sexual harassment and assault against women, non-binary and other marginalised people. The teacher thus encourages students to uncover voices that were made less visible through time, and consider themselves editors:

"It's saying, you're an editor, you can edit anything. You learn the skills of editing and you can do a medieval text, or Twitter—then all that could merge, it could be 'Chaucer on Twitter' or it could be a 19th century set of letters by a Chaucer editor."

(ID: *T2*)

Specific to translation, *T1* asked for student contributions to medieval romance translations as a form of 'code-cracking puzzle'. This problem-solving technique was most effective as part of a group, where students negotiated their respective translations of the text. As a teaching instructor, *S10* inspired other students to reflect collectively on the translation decision-making process, resulting in their selection and annotation of words which required more flexibility to translate. She suggests students often have the raw curiosity that some experienced scholars may not:

"There's a lot of this unquestioned inherited knowledge that I find that my students can often just push through. We look up a word in the Oxford English Dictionary and they're like, 'why can't it mean this instead?', and I'm like, 'I don't know, maybe it does mean that!'"

(ID: *S10*)

Consequently, students are keen to make translation decisions accessible and visible, and share relevant secondary literature for their course, forming key principles of academic learning that can be applied to the use of new technologies. Student's ability to experiment intuitively with different digital methods for analysing Chaucer's works must also be encouraged if they choose to utilise AI.

Students also provided in-depth critique of generative AI in digital editing and translation, with positive and negative implications of its use. *S4* and *S6* agreed on AI's lack of reliability and representativeness in interpreting Chaucer's works, particularly in its earliest stages where it may not draw on peer-reviewed scholarship.⁴ *S6* was unsure whether ChatGPT could reliably produce high quality translations, more so than a human. As referenced by his peers, *S3* recognised generative AI's susceptibility for error, but suggested LLMs may provide an exercise in "flip[ping] the teacher-student roles". He stated that students could acknowledge the likelihood of inaccurate medieval translations, and rectify them as part of a method of "learning in reverse engineering" (ID: *S3*). From a critical AI perspective, Conrad and Goodlad (2024) urge students to "probe the biases of generative tools", to develop key critical thinking skills for regularly questioning the provenance of all sources. This probing might involve identifying cases where bias and harm is reproduced through translations now considered derogatory towards character identities that are pushed to the margins of society. *S13* participated in this type of exercise, where she wrote a critical scholarly essay, prompted ChatGPT to do the same, and compared the two outputs as part of an assignment. She raised an idea for a similar activity, where students translate passages of Chaucer's texts and compare their outputs alongside an LLM's, suggesting it would be "illuminating" for the student for fostering deeper skills in reflection and critique.

In terms of teacher attitudes towards generative AI in HE, ethical and practical implications were acknowledged and highlighted to students, with curiosity about reversing teacher-student roles when experimenting with outputs. *S12* explained that her teacher permitted a more investigative approach to AI, if students flagged this type of AI use in their assignments. Her teacher was "really curious about the implications of AI and how that's going to change how we are able to convey information with one another"; an intriguing comparison with historical processes of text dissemination and translation. The idea is that the use of AI might form possible research questions for further exploration by students, comparing the production and reception of text through time. *T6* also stressed the role of the human editor alongside ChatGPT translations, and that analysis of machine translation could form part of assignments or classroom tasks, especially if we are to empower students to become critical editors. The educators interviewed were taking the necessary precautions to acknowledge the presence of generative AI in HE, by creating lesson plans and assignments to subvert plagiaristic use. They are actively developing students' agency to reflect on different methods of learning and interrogate all sources regardless of their origin.

Critical Thinking Development in Chaucer and Medieval Translation Studies with Generative AI

Despite signs of decreasing engagement within Chaucer studies at further and higher education institutions (e.g. Edwards, 2021), scholars and educators are incorporating an interrogation of Chaucer's position on the curriculum by reading and interpreting his works through different lenses. There are clear opportunities for students to develop nuanced understanding of the past and its impact on the present, uncover intricate etymologies of the language used today, and critique different sources as they become further removed from the 'original text'.⁵ As previously mentioned, Baechle and Harris' (2021) work on the ethical implications of studying Chaucer highlight student investigations into historical attitudes towards marginalised people. Crucially, these skills must be sustained throughout the use of generative AI learning tools. Here, I explore

some of the barriers in Chaucer studies, which in turn cause challenges for LLM's interpretation of these issues.

Students and teachers were prompted to discuss the most salient topics in Chaucer studies, which encouraged critique and interrogation of the author, his biography and comparisons of the past and present. In particular, the notion of sin in medieval Christianity is a topic underpinning much of the discussion about sexuality, gender, race and the global context of Chaucer's works. It also includes Chaucer's own critique of the Catholic Church through the 'corrupt' Pardoner (e.g. see Rabiee's (2012) analysis of the Pardoner as a representation of hypocrisy). *S2* and *S4* mentioned the suppression of queerness and its link to 'sin' during the medieval period. *S2* was interested in the satirical elements of Chaucer's works, and *S4* extended this analysis of discrimination to medieval French and Italian writers' perceptions. *S5* also referenced the surprising differences between medieval Christianity and the religion of her country of birth, including the blurred boundaries around sin in the medieval period. *T1* asks students to consider the parallels between Chaucer's characters and their queerness and gender fluidity. The Pardoner and the character of Absolon in *The Miller's Tale* are portrayed as 'effeminate', and students are interested in understanding whether today's gender stereotypes were also the concern of medieval audiences. *S8* and *S9* related to one another's interests on the treatment of women in Chaucer's works, speaking to the absence of more stereotypical archetypes of women as "the carer or the villain" (ID: *S9*). Alternatively, *S12* recognised the link between Chaucer's biography and the treatment of women in his works, including recently 'debunked' allegations of sexual assault against Cecily Chaumpaigne (e.g. see Kathryn Walton's (2022) and Carissa Harris' (2023) remarks on this subject). She recognised that narratives of rape culture should be explored while "investigating people that are not typically investigated" (ID: *S12*).

There is also freedom to explore the medieval global context when interpreting Chaucer's works. Through the opportunities of his Chaucer classes, *S1* studied the role of the immortal Old Man in *The Pardoner's Tale*, focusing on Buddhism and the legend of Pindola, one of the Eighteen Arhats who was also "doomed to wander the Earth forever" (ID: *S1*). *T4* and *T5* agreed on the need for international and decolonial perspectives of Chaucer. *T4* stated that the analysis of Chaucer's works actively encourages students to deal with anti-Semitic depictions, the relations between Christianity and Islam, and develop critical responses and translations. Students thus negotiate Chaucer's 'intentions', the othering of medieval identities, and the transmission of this information through text over time. When generative AI is introduced with the intention of increasing this access further, students must be encouraged to recognise different literary interpretations and gain the experience to assess the accuracy of the generated output.

T1 also refers to the linguistic challenges of translating Middle English, particularly grammar (inflectional morphology and syntactic structure), but states that students enjoy and excel with etymology and loan words, style (tone, satire, irony, etc.), Chaucerian rhyming patterns and spelling variation. Despite time constraints, she mentions she runs language help sessions for students whose language background is not Germanic and therefore close to Middle English. There is therefore emphasis on additional support and resources, but if AI is employed by students, how might the technology assist, or even hinder, translation tasks? Can LLMs replicate the nuanced and sensitive nature of the topics studied within Chaucer's works today?

It became apparent that a freer and more visible approach to translation was at the forefront of students' minds. This approach a) rectifies some of the difficulties of learning and reading Middle English, and b) allows students to bring their lived experience from their own communities to the practice of translation experimentation, both of which are necessary for critiquing AI outputs. Graduate students *S10* and *S11* mentioned flexibility when teaching less experienced students about medieval translation. *S10* mentioned that some of the medieval excerpts and translations she encountered in the literature had “racist connotations” or were “strongly gendered” (ID: *S10*). Instead, she found ways to weave her own perspectives of the medieval period into her translations, encouraging her students to do the same:

“I’m not teaching a lot of specialist classes, but I want them to feel empowered to look at a page from the Wife of Bath in the Middle English, and feel like they have legitimate interpretations of that stuff, and that they might have insights that scholars [...] don’t have because they’re kind of in their ‘scholar box’.”

(ID: *S10*)

This adaptable approach to translation brings an element of visibility to the decision-making process, as editors feel inclined to share their thought process, especially if the works have not been literally translated. *S11* agreed, stating that the order to which students read *The Canterbury Tales* also affects their interpretation of the characters. By reading about the Wife of Bath before the Pardoner, her instructor constructed a negative opinion of the Pardoner, who believed he was “being satirised into a straight player” rather than embodying the empowerment of the Wife of Bath. *S11* noted that if the characters had been read in the reverse way, against the scribe’s intentions, his perceptions of the Pardoner may have been different. On a similar note, *T3* encourages flexibility by allowing students free reign with their translation assignment and commentary. They are permitted to focus on the grammar, prosody, or the sociocultural, historical and religious context. These insights suggest there is moveability in the translation experience; there may be core translation principles, but taking translation in a direction comfortable to that of the translator might alleviate concerns about one-to-one mapping and negative portrayals of characters, while ensuring the process is documented transparently.

This transparency is arguably more critical when it comes to LLM translation. There are known ethical issues of generative AI, related to the lack of training data on actual scholarly translation practices, replication of harmful stereotypes, and no method of tracing authorship. The academic principles reinforced by teachers in Chaucer and medieval studies emphasise the work being done to build critical thinking skills from the outset of a degree programme. They provide students with the permission to fail and try again, a core aspect of the experimentation process involving cooperation with peers to select the most appropriate interpretation. LLMs do not inherently offer these critical perspectives for questioning translation choices, and if they are to be used, they must be embedded in a pedagogical process where there are established roots of experimentation, critique, and most importantly, sharing of feedback.

Knowledge Sharing via Critical and Collaborative AI Translation

The *C21 Editions* team developed a digital teaching edition prototype for *The Pardoner's Prologue and Tale* (henceforth, PPT), centring student and teacher insights on classroom experimentation and collaboration, and the importance of building reflection and feedback into the learning of medieval tales. The edition included transcriptions from the Ellesmere manuscript (held at the University of Sheffield, 2013), with accompanying digitised manuscript images. Modern English translations of these transcriptions were produced by generative AI, with both human and text-to-speech recordings of the tale. The text was also accompanied by AI-generated annotations and linked topic guides. Each feature was built alongside extensive checking by the project's editor, to emphasise the human component of building digital editions.⁶ These features are intended to introduce students to the textual and oral tradition of Chaucerian and medieval tales, so they become aware of the multiple layers involved in medieval text transmission (e.g. how the existence of manuscript variants, different scribal hands, editions and adaptations all affect interpretation) before proceeding with independent inquiry. Figure 1 shows an early instantiation of the prototype interface landing page and an overview of these features.

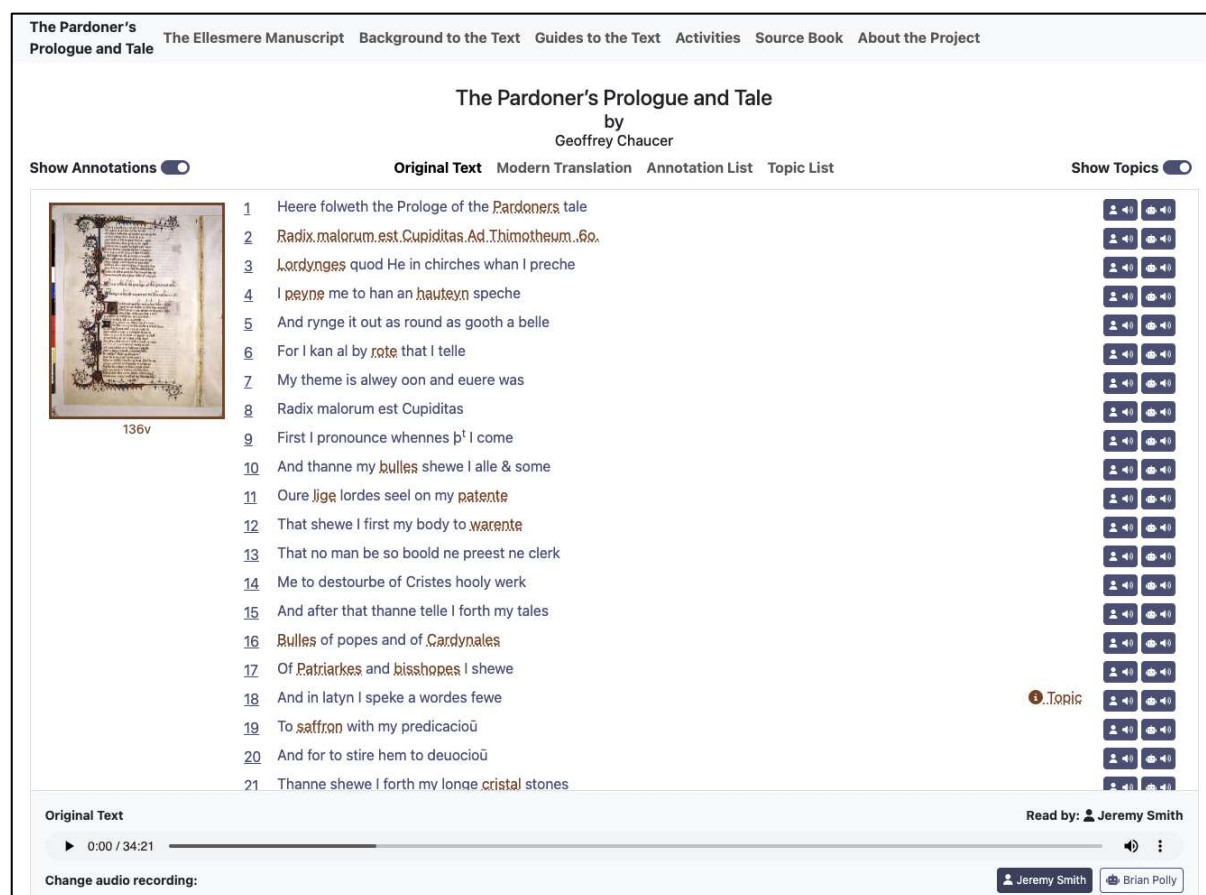


Figure 1: A digital prototype interface of *The Pardoner's Prologue and Tale* by Geoffrey Chaucer, as produced by the *C21 Editions* project. This screenshot provides an overview of the AI-assisted features prior to its publication.

Zooming in on AI-generated translation for PPT provides an initial window into the level of human critical thinking, reflection and problem-solving required by the editor and learner to maintain accuracy and room for creativity. A number of the translations produced by, in this case,

ChatGPT-3.5, were added to student ‘activities’ within the edition. The aims of these activities were to a) provide transparency as to where the editor updated the AI-generated translation; b) offer opportunities to compare different translations (human or AI), bringing in the student-friendly Harvard Geoffrey Chaucer translation (Benson, 1980-2024); and c) point to useful discussion via hidden ‘help’ sections and encourage students to incorporate their expertise into these translations via collaborative discussion boards. I focus on one example from PPT—the use of *ioly wenche* by the Pardoner when preaching about his ‘sins’, to describe the tavern sex workers he encountered.⁷

Task:

Your task is to share your thoughts with others on the discussion board about various modern English translations of the *Pardoner’s Prologue and Tale* (made by either a human or generative AI) and how appropriate these are for a modern reader.

You might cover topics related to: language (semantic) change, etymology and words loaned via language contact, the representation of gender and social hierarchies, and Chaucer’s own language, portrayal of characters and interpretation of medieval society.

Figure 2: Part of the translation activity introducing the specific task. The task is intentionally left open for students to provide their interpretation of the translations on the discussion board.

Transcription: Original text transcription from the Ellesmere manuscript
Translation 1: Translation from ChatGPT, alongside the editor
Translation 2: Translation from Harvard’s Geoffrey Chaucer website

Figure 3: A key for the activity, detailing: the diplomatic transcription from the Ellesmere manuscript, the ChatGPT translation alongside the editor, and a translation from Harvard’s Geoffrey Chaucer website (Benson, 1980-2024).

Ioly Wenche

The Pardoner discusses what he would rather do with his riches in his prologue:

126 Nay I wol drynke licour of the vyne
127 And haue a *ioly wenche* in euery toun

Transcription: And haue a **ioly wenche** in euery toun

Translation 1: And have a **jolly wench** in every town.

Translation 2: And have a **pretty wench** in every town.

Help [collapse]

Carissa Harris states that, through time, ‘wench’ came to be known as a ‘structural position’, rather than a ‘gender identity’. She states that “the label of wench is capacious enough to include many, yet binding enough to compel to coerce and to constrain” (Harris 2023). Its roots are the product of colonialism and slavery, and the modern-day use of the term is embedded in racialised misogyny arising from the 17th century.

The medieval use of the term is also encompassed by negative connotations of women in society. In the OED, the term ‘*wench*’ is derived from Old English ‘*wence!*’, a now obsolete meaning to refer to “a child (of either sex)” or ‘a servant or slave; also, a common woman” (OED Online, ‘*wenche* (n.)’ 2024). Harris (2023) explains that ‘wench’ is used in Chaucer for the purposes of control and coercion, domination, and to denote masculine possession, and is often used to justify violence against those with a degraded social position.

The same could be said of the use of ‘wench’ in the Pardoner’s prologue. In this case, the use of *ioly* as a premodifier for ‘wench’ objectifies the woman’s body as central to the Pardoner’s pleasure. In Translation 2, *ioly* is translated as ‘pretty’, which may relate to the physical sense in the OED of ‘having the freshness and lively spirits of youth or good health; fresh, lively, sprightly, spirited’ (OED Online, ‘*jolly* (adj. & adv.)’ 2023), or in the MED where *joli* is presented as “pleasant, beautiful, pretty, elegant, excellent”. While the Pardoner might be simply expressing his sexual desires and sin, regardless of his ‘responsibilities’ within the church, Chaucer’s use of the term in this context appears to be embedded in a societal expectation that women be controlled and objectified.

Figure 4: The ‘ioly wenche’ sub-activity, with an extract directly from the text (linked to an annotation of the term), the transcription and translations comparison box, and a collapsible help section to provide students with further discussion pointers.

Figures 2-4 show the task instructions, along with the extract of the activity and tale featuring *ioly wenche*. The use of *ioly wenche* in PPT yields necessary discussion about the etymology of ‘wench’ through the history of English, which is not accessible via equivalent translations of the term. Here, Chaucer’s Pardoner uses ‘wench’ as part of the sermon he delivers and to admit to his deceitful practices, explaining that he sells relics lacking in spiritual power to his audiences and uses the money to commit further tavern sins. Firstly, ChatGPT-3.5 translates literally, to ‘jolly wench’, and there are implications for the meaning of ‘jolly’ in this context. In the Middle English Dictionary (MED, ‘*joli* adj.’, 1951-2001), there are many meanings of *ioly*, including one used frequently today (“merry, cheerful, glad, joyful, happy”); and two other senses, “playful, frisky;

amorous, lecherous” and “pleasing, comely, beautiful, handsome”. The use of *ioly* in PPT is likely to be a combination of the latter two senses, given the negative portrayal of women in the medieval period. Harvard’s Geoffrey Chaucer website uses ‘pretty’, yet there is no annotation of this etymological information. Secondly, literal translations with no accompanying annotation do not highlight semantic developments, which are especially relevant for ‘wench’. Carissa Harris has written extensively on the subject of ‘wench’, and its use by Chaucer and other medieval writers, noting the structural and colonial implications of the label in addition to its gendered roots. As noted in our student ‘help’ section, “the label of wench is capacious enough to include many, yet binding enough to compel to coerce and to constrain” (Harris, 2023). The term is both rooted in negative perspectives of women in medieval history, with the earliest attestation being Old English *wenche*, meaning “a child (of either sex)” or “a servant or slave; also, a common woman” (OED, ‘wenche (*n.*)’, 2023), and is embedded in colonialism, slavery and misogyny from the 17th century. Harris (2023) explains that the term therefore encompasses coercion, domination and male possession against people whose social position has been degraded. These meanings are not immediately obvious to students who may only know its limited modern usage. However, it is vital to show where the term’s control over all those marginalised by medieval society stemmed from and progressed through history.

The history of the racialisation of the term ‘wench’ is neither noted by genAI (at the time of prompting), alongside its generated translation, nor is it evident with further probing.⁸ When prompted to annotate the term further, ChatGPT responded: “wenche: In Middle English, a phrase for a pretty or cheerful young woman. Modern English retains the positive associations of this phrase even as 'wench' has taken on more negative or derogatory connotations.”⁹ In this case, the LLM has recognised the descriptor as ‘pretty’, yet provided general description highlighting women’s ‘negative’ and ‘derogatory’ treatment, without any etymological information on race and coercion. Part of West et al.’s ‘Generative AI Paradox’ shows that LLMs comprehend in non-human-like ways. LLMs can undertake complicated tasks before gaining basic understanding of a concept, preferring distributional accuracy over individual accuracy (West et al., 2024, p. 8). For interpretations of medieval language and text, this processing would likely lead to generic responses lacking in nuance on the historical context, as they may homogenise interpretations.

The above example highlights the specific flaws of AI-generated translations. At the same time, it presents an opportunity for students to learn more about medieval terms, or bring in their own perspective to challenge translations. Our digital teaching edition makes room for students to comment on these issues via Padlet discussion boards, mimicking social media-based interaction through comments and ‘likes’. We took inspiration from the crowdsourced nature of translation, through endeavours such as *Beowulf By All* (Abbott, Treharne and Fafinski, 2021), which drew on the perspectives of translators from different communities, and *The Global Medieval Sourcebook* (Velloso-Lyons, Dombrowski and Starkey, 2021), which curated a digital repository of medieval texts and translations for teaching and researching purposes. A teacher in our user study emphasised that evolving editions require continual input from student editors and writers, as well as professionals in digital editing, to enrich translations via multiple interpretations. She participated in a *Piers Plowman* reading group, with the following format:

“We’re invited to translate them as imaginatively as we want, and then we come back and share all our different translations. It’s hard to know how you might represent that in a static form, but it’s highly generative and of course, getting students to participate in these things is absolutely invaluable.”

(ID: T6)

Knowledge sharing and feedback is crucial for building digital teaching editions, particularly those generated alongside AI, hence the need for online discussion boards that are regularly monitored.¹⁰ The inclusion of AI also acts as a springboard for additional discussion which may not have arisen had the translations not been monitored closely for accuracy. The challenge is then determining how best to represent multiple insights in a static edition, which I leave for our future work on editorial workflows that assess AI-generated translations and guides. This snapshot of possible translation activities in the classroom thus exemplifies how students can become a voice of authority on future technologies, and sustain interest in Chaucer’s place on the curriculum and the roots of medieval textual culture.

Conclusion

Using generative AI in Chaucer studies can result in higher levels of understanding, commentary and critique on Chaucer’s works and the medieval period, but only when LLMs are placed in a cyclical process of reflection, agency, and authority. LLMs benefit students via ‘reverse engineering’, as proposed by a student in our focus groups. If students prepare to interpret Chaucer’s works thoroughly, they are then positioned to tackle the flaws and biases produced by the LLM. If students have little experience of reading and translating Chaucer’s Middle English, generative AI models might only provide an introductory-level overview of topics on medieval society, and these students require additional support by educators. The *C21 Editions* digital teaching edition places accessibility at the forefront of translating Chaucer, encouraging extensive learning about the topic before prompting AI. The insights provided in this paper establish the main practices within Chaucer studies. On these courses, there is room to question whether reading Chaucer’s texts can lead to increased knowledge on the othering of identities through time, and produce proposals for new digital resources that investigate historical textual traditions. The aim of this case study was to show how and why insights from the learning and editorial community on experimentation, collaboration, critique and flexibility are important for challenging new technologies as part of pedagogy. Digital teaching editions offer a pathway to critique the humanities by examining inherently flawed sources, and contribute fresh knowledge to the development of technologies, whether that be in the form of TEI guidelines, workflows and processes in the GLAM sector, or for wider public use.

In future research, I look to further explore TEI approaches to embedding multiple insights on medieval translation and textual interpretation. In the age of increased competition to produce the most advanced LLMs, it is important to document interdisciplinary perspectives of these technologies. This means communicating the value of the digital for humanities, educational institutions, and technology industries, where nuanced critiques of these new technologies are possible. Prompt engineering is also a crucial endeavour, to determine how best to elicit the

responses students require from LLMs – without stepping into plagiarism territory – and if this is not possible, students must be encouraged to adopt agency around AI decision-making. The key benefit to digital collaboration in this way, as suggested by Harris (2023, p. 15), is embracing failure in academia, which must incorporate modified learning outcomes to allow students to “screw around” with new digital tools. There are also questions surrounding whether AI has the ‘originality’ to reimagine Chaucerian tales. Students who learn from contemporary authors such as Patience Agbabi and her authentic voice that comes through while adopting the Chaucerian frame narrative (Agbabi and Barrington, 2024), might also learn from comparing genuine human creation with artificial responses, which simultaneously emphasises the role of the human in adapting popular medieval literature. As Guldi (2022, p. 112) notes, “the cyborg is here to *lend* non-human intelligence, not to substitute for human intelligence”. Digital pedagogical editions, including our Chaucer interface, thus raise important questions about voice and narrative through the critique of generative AI, by adding, and not substituting, further comprehension of the medieval period to a student’s journey through Chaucerian literature.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Key of Student and Teacher IDs

Focus group 1 (UK university, in-person)

- S1: Third year Joint Honours student in English Language and Linguistics and History
- S2: Fourth year Honours student in English Language and Linguistics

Focus group 2 (UK university, in-person)

- S3: Fourth year Honours student in English Literature¹¹
- S4: Third year Honours student in English Language and Linguistics
- S5: First year MSc (Masters) student in Applied Linguistics
- S6: Fourth year Honours student in English Language and Literature

Focus group 3 (UK university, in-person)

- S7: Third year undergraduate student in English Language and Literature
- S8: Second year undergraduate student in English Literature
- S9: First year undergraduate student in English Language and Linguistics

Focus group 4 (US university, online)

- S10: Fifth year graduate (PhD) student in English Literature
- S11: Third year graduate (PhD) student in Medieval Literature
- S12: Second year MA (Masters) student in English Literature
- S13: Senior year student in English (research-based)

Interview 1 (UK university, online)

- T1: Lecturer in Middle English Literature

Interview 2 (UK university, in-person)

- T2: Professor of English Language and Manuscript Studies

Interview 3 (UK university, in-person)

- T3: Lecturer in English Language and Linguistics

Interview 4 (UK university, online)

- T4: Lecturer in Medieval Literature
- T5: Senior Lecturer in English Historical Linguistics

Interview 5 (US university, online)

- T6: Professor of Middle English Literature

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¹ The Pardoner's gender and sexuality has been the focus of many scholarly papers. Chaucer introduces his character in the General Prologue to *The Canterbury Tales* with the line, *I trowe he were a geldyng or a mare*. Consequently, secondary literature has referenced his status as a "eunuch [sic]" (e.g. Dinshaw, 1989, p. 156) and his queer identity. I encourage the reader to refer to the etymologies of *geldyng* and *mare* in the Oxford English Dictionary, or the linked data resource 'Homosaurus' for further analysis of the semantic changes to the translated terms.

² I use the term 'Englises' to reference the numerous adaptations of Chaucer's works which do not use a literally equivalent translation or 'standardised' English. For instance, Patience Agbabi's *Telling Tales* draws on the multicultural and linguistic influences in London to tell the stories of communities beyond the elite few often discussed in popular medieval literature.

³ This study received ethics approval from the University of Sheffield Research Ethics Committee, and was administered by the Digital Humanities Institute (DHI). All students and teachers in our study received information sheets about their participation. They all provided their informed consent to contribute to the project and have their responses published by the DHI data service and in future research articles. As part of their consent to taking part, the names and affiliations of students and teachers in our findings have been anonymised and assigned an ID number. This number is linked to details about their degree course and year of study, or career stage and research area, but without identifying information about their specific institution (see Appendix 1).

⁴ OpenAI's ChatGPT version 3.5 was freely available to the public at the time of conducting the user studies, between June and September 2023.

⁵ I use 'original text' here, but recognise the gap in our knowledge of medieval authors' intentions for a text and its reception, as there are many layers of scribal activity before the text reached its past and present audiences.

⁶ Discussion documenting the transparency of the use of AI has been published on the *C21 Editions* project's sourcebook; see Whittle (2025).

⁷ This example shows the end result of working alongside AI-generated translations, but I recognise the importance of testing and detailing the types of prompts engineered to produce such responses. I point to this necessary endeavour in the concluding paragraphs. I also direct the reader to our edition's sourcebook, which indicates the specific prompts used to generate outputs and provides some additional examples of the method's accuracy and suitability for digital editing (see Whittle, Groves, Pidd and Wessels, 2025).

⁸ The reference to 'further probing' is relevant for students who would need to acquire the knowledge of the history of the term in order to prompt ChatGPT about the racialised roots of 'wench'. ChatGPT-3.5 does not seem to draw on this extensive history when enquiring about the etymology of the term.

⁹ To test ChatGPT's capabilities for producing translation activities, the following prompt was written: "Produce an activity for university-level undergraduate students which allows them to investigate the use of the following words from the Chaucer's Pardoner's Prologue and Tale. Each of the words and their translations relate to referents in the text with different perceived characteristics or roles, all with unique etymologies. Please also include a brief description of each word in relation to data in the Oxford English Dictionary and Middle English Dictionary. Finally, include a summary for each translation which serves as a prompt for the students, explaining some of the reasons behind the choices of these translations: Middle English 'dame' > Modern English 'mother' or 'dame' ME 'frutesteres' > ModE 'fruit sellers' or 'girls selling fruits' ME 'the gretteste' > ModE 'the greatest' or 'the greatest men' ME 'hyne' > ModE 'servant' or 'labourer' ME 'ioly wenche' > ModE 'jolly wench' or 'pretty wench' ME 'kaityf' > ModE 'caitiff' or 'wretch' ME 'knaue' > ModE 'knave' or 'servant' ME 'lewed peple' > ModE 'unlearned people', 'lewd people' or 'ignorant people' ME 'lordynges' > ModE 'lords' or 'gentlemen' ME 'page' > ModE 'page' or 'servant boy' ME 'shrewe' > ModE 'shrew', 'evil person', or 'scoundrel'."

¹⁰ Theories of connectivism in learning (e.g. Utecht and Keller, 2019; Corbett and Spinello, 2020) highlight that crowd-created content is not less valid, but crucial to the process of learning, unlearning and relearning in HE. I refer to theories of social learning, and their relevance for digital pedagogy and generative AI translation, only briefly here, but encourage the reader to explore the overall value of digital teaching editions for all aspects of medieval text interpretation (e.g. see Whittle, 2024).

¹¹ Honours students have the opportunity to pursue and qualify with a Master of Arts degree, completing four years over their course.